For this case study, let's look at **Phishing**, specifically a sophisticated variant known as "Business Email Compromise" (BEC), which has become a massive headache for both students and professionals.

Case Study: The "Urgent Internship Stipend" Scam

What is the crime?

Phishing is a form of social engineering where an attacker masquerades as a trusted entity to trick victims into revealing sensitive information like login credentials, credit card numbers, or Social Security digits.

How it happens:

1. A student receives an email that appears to come from the University's Financial Aid office or a high-ranking Professor. The subject line usually screams urgency: *"Action Required: Your Summer Stipend is Pending."*
2. The email contains a link to a "secure portal" that looks identical to the university's actual login page.
3. The student enters their username and password. Instead of seeing a stipend, they are redirected back to the real university homepage, often unaware they just handed their credentials to a hacker.
4. The attacker uses those credentials to access the student's portal, reroute direct deposit information to a foreign bank account, and scrape personal data for further identity theft.

Who is targeted?

While anyone with an inbox is a target, students are frequently singled out during high-stress periods, such as finals week or the start of a semester, when they are more likely to skim emails and miss red flags.

The Consequences:

The fallout is often twofold. Financially, students can lose thousands in tuition or grant money. Reputationally, the attacker may use the compromised student account to send thousands of spam emails, leading to the student's account being blacklisted or suspended by the university IT department.

Red Flags to Watch For:

- The name says "Financial Aid," but the email address is admin@stipend-portal-edu.com instead of .edu.
- Excessive use of "Urgent," "Immediate," or "Final Warning."
- Hovering over a button reveals a URL that doesn’t match the official school domain.